

With Millers, Baseball Characters Were Dime a Dozen

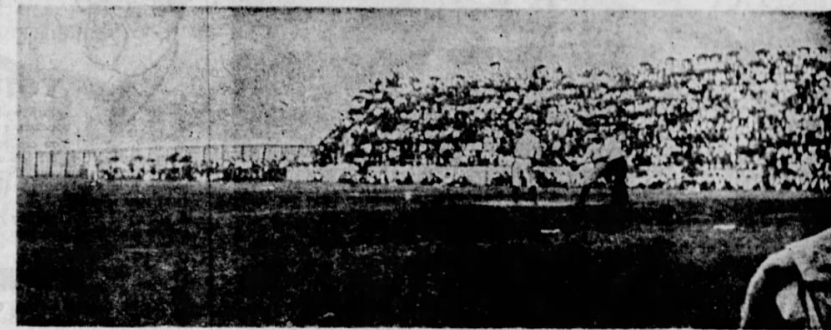
By HALSEY HALL
Sunday Tribune Staff Writer
It often has been said: "If you are a character in baseball, you have played or will play, for a few games anyway, with the Minneapolis Millers."—All except Dizzy Dean.

Baseball's greatest character of all time—Rube Waddell—pitched here. Yes and pitched well, for the Rube won 20 games in 1911. He stayed in line pretty well, too, for colorful Joe (Pongo) Cantillon knew how to handle him. If he won, "go on out fishing" was the verdict. Rube could chase fire engines as much as his big heart desired. That and fishing and drinking were his greatest delights.

OF COURSE, there was the time drinking won out over the stuff you find in lakes. Rube was given permission to go fishing but overstayed his leave. Joe Cantillon and brother Mike, the owner, were wrathful indeed. They were appeased when they received a mess of fish from the contrite Rube, who could be Little Boy Blue in the corner when he so desired.

So things were rosy again . . . until the Cantillons received a bill from Yerxa's meat market for the fish which Rube had "caught" there.

Joe brought down Sherry Magee, a real roisterer of the old school, who feared neither man nor beast. A murderous hitter, a murderous man when mad. In a small southern city on a spring training trip, Sherwood was served a tough steak. He asked the waiter for nails and a hammer and



AUG. 27, 1899—MINNEAPOLIS 13, INDIANAPOLIS 8, AT OLD MINNEHAHA FIELD
Perry Werden at bat. Note fence in back. Courtesy of Dr. R. William Ackley and a Mrs. Amlaxson, Mike Cantillon's secretary

the proprietor. The boss arrived and, before his horror-mirrored eyes, Magee nailed the steak to the floor of the dining room.

COLORFUL GUYS, too, inhabited Nicollet. Gavy Cravath went up from Minneapolis as the right-handed Babe Ruth of his day. He hit 29 homers for the Millers for a record, then hit 29 for the Phillies for another mark. And Gavy came back down here to finish up.

Then came Zach Wheat, Reb Russell, Bill McKechnie, Jim Delahanty, Claude Rossman, Jim Williams, Hobe Ferris, Roy Patterson, Elmer Foster, Walter Wilmot, Russ Ford, Bob Meusel, Jesse Tannehill, Bubbles Hargrave, Tom Hughes and a host of others.

There was the terrific trio of Red Kress, Carl Reynolds and Dusty Cooke in 1937.

THE PRESENT Miller boss is Rosy Ryan. He, Jesse Petty and Rube Benton came out of major league glory to form a tremendous triumvirate in the thirties. Old Rube was a caution.

Like that other Rube, Mr. Waddell, Benton loved spirits but he also loved to pitch and fish. So, when he'd win a tough one, Bush chased him out to the lakes and Rube could be gone two or three days if he so wished.

Then there was Unser Choe Hauser. If asked to name Minneapolis' all-time favorites, I'd name Joe Hauser first and Ray Dandridge second.

HAUSER HAD two loves—

hitting and bridge. When he belted 69 home runs in 1933 he was just about as happy as when he and Andy Cohen "invaded" a shark's bridgeclub in the Deshler hotel in Columbus, Ohio, and cleaned up the local prizes at fairly reasonable stakes.

Then there was pitcher Pat Malone of 1924 vintage. Pat loved a jolly rough time and a fight that might be accompanying it was OK with him. He and teammate Dick Loftus had quite a stunt when stopping at hotels on the road.

PAT, BIG AND BURLY, would sit the slender Loftus astride his shoulders. They had purchased an extra long overcoat somewhere and this would be draped on Loftus,

completely concealing the upper part of the Malone body. Richard then would put on a high plug hat, and the boys were ready.

Malone would stalk through hotel corridors and lobbies and, from his 10-foot height, the handsome Loftus would doff his hat to all the ladies.

Ted Williams? Ted was in the fire-chasing stage when a Miller in 1938. A fire engine would roar by on Nicollet avenue and Bush would peer fearfully out into right field to see if his boy still was there. Ted was a glove-thrower then, too, and one day, in a particular fit of pique, he put his fist right through the big glass water bottle on the bench . . . And didn't hurt himself.

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